



### Google's first game studio

Google has opened its first games studio in Montreal - headed by industry veteran Jade Raymond. <https://digit.in/nov19-11>



### Cash App Scams

Twitter and Instagram have become flooded with scams targeting users of Cash App, a p2p payment service. <https://digit.in/nov19-12>

provide vague descriptions. Now, AI has been employed thoroughly to allow descriptions to be more holistic by recognising certain actions such as walking, eating, and more.

Using Facebook's inbuilt facial recognition, the description can also include the names of people tagged in images. The Accessibility Team also added support for 25 different languages. They are now looking into developing a functionality that would allow a user to converse with Facebook's AI about a photo.

Instagram, which is owned by Facebook, also includes features to generate descriptions of photos using object detection technology.

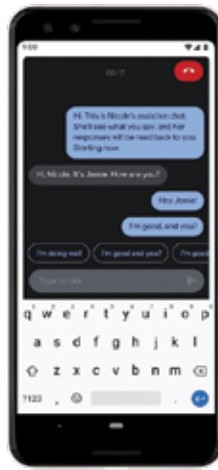
### GOOGLE

Launched in 2013, Google's Accessibility team were tasked with overseeing employee training and user research related to disabilities to ultimately ensure that all their products were as accessible as possible. Now, the company claims that all their products undergo a standardised accessibility test.

Some of the more recent endeavours the company has undertaken on this front include ChromeVox, a free screen reader for visually-impaired users, wheelchair accessible routes integrated into Google Maps for several cities such as Boston, London, Sydney, Tokyo and more, and the Lookout app.

Lookout helps visually-impaired people navigate around by identifying objects through the user's camera and lets them know about objects or obstacles in the way. It can also read the text on signs and labels, scan barcodes and recognise currencies.

In May, at the I/O 2019 developer conference, the tech giant also revealed three AI projects targeted towards the disabled. Project Euphonia attempts to improve a computers' ability to understand individuals who have



Google's Live Relay enables deaf or hard-of-hearing people to make phone calls

speech impairments. Live Relay uses speech recognition and text-to-speech technology to make voice calls accessible to the deaf or hard of hearing. Lastly, there's Project Diva, which stands for DIVERsely Assisted, which allows individuals to interact with Google Assistant in a non-verbal manner. An external, trigger device resembling a button is used to relay commands to Google Assistant.

### MICROSOFT

Tech mammoth, Microsoft, has an AI for Accessibility

program which has committed \$25 million over the next five years to build technology and improve accessibility for disabled people across the globe using Microsoft products. Additionally, the company has a service called Windows Narrator that has now been upgraded to be more responsive and incorporates new features such as the ability to customise pitch, volume, reading speed in order to denote formatting such as bolded, capitalised, italicised, or underlined text.

Similar to Google's Live Relay, Microsoft brought out Seeing AI in 2017, which is a free app that assists the visually-impaired by turning the "visual world into an audible experience". The app can identify and narrate things such as colours, currency, handwriting, barcodes and more using the user's phone camera. It can even describe people and their emotions.



Seeing AI by Microsoft. The caption says "25-year old woman with black hair looking happy"

### ASSISTIVE TECHNOLOGY PRODUCTS AND SERVICES

From video game controllers for the disabled to robotic exoskeletons, the world of consumer technology is slowly but surely evolving to become more inclusive and universally accessible. Here are a few gadgets that could revolutionise life for people with chronic illnesses or disabilities.

#### Xfinity Eye Detection

Comcast recently unveiled some new features to their Xfinity X1 cable package that uses eye detection technology that enables people with mobility limitations to change the channel, access the guide, record shows and even open some apps by just using eye motions. This free-to-use software can even be used on tablets and laptops and it works seamlessly with already-existing hardware and software on devices, so users will not have to purchase a new set of gadgets to enjoy the benefits of this service.

#### AirPod Hearing Aid Mode

Apple, with their revolutionary AirPods, not only changed the wireless headphones industry but also helped



those with hearing disabilities. The Live Listen feature in iOS 12 turns your AirPods into hearing aids by amplifying the sound around you. It achieves this by using the microphone present on the iPhone and then amplifies and pipes this audio right into your AirPods. If you want to activate this feature, Open Settings on your iPhone, go to Control Center and then select Customize Controls. Next, tap the green plus (+) button next to Hearing and add it to your control center list. You can now enter control centre by swiping